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Copy-Paste in the Theban Necropolis: Textual and Iconographic Parallels between Rekhmire's *jnw*-scene and Hatshepsut's *Pwnt* Inscriptions

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Rekhmire, his Tomb, and the *jnw*-contributions Scene

This article aims to show that the captions of the registers of *Pwnt* and the Southern Countries, in the scene of the delivery of *jnw*-contributions in Rekhmire's tomb, are not original compositions. Instead, they appear to be a collation of various clauses from Hatshepsut's Expedition to *Pwnt* at Deir el-Bahri or a related lost document. Similarities can be observed also at the iconographic level, with elements in Rekhmire's African registers having parallels in scenes associated with one of Hatshepsut's texts. The article explores these parallels and proposes some scenarios to explain them, including the possibility that both Hatshepsut's and Rekhmire's texts derive from an earlier, lost prototype. The conclusions offer some considerations on the broader implications of these observations, such as the historicity of such scenes (e.g., in relation to the Aegean register of Rekhmire's scene).

Rekhmire served as governor of Thebes and *ỉ3tʸ* during the reigns of Thutmose III and Amenhotep II.[1] His tomb, TT100, is located in Sheikh Abd el-Qurna, in the Theban necropolis.[2] Rekhmire's tomb is lavishly decorated with a repertoire of scenes not unique for the time, including offering scenes and representations of his functions and important events in relation to his life as a servant of the state.

The scene discussed in this article is located on the north wall on the left side (from the entrance) of the transverse hall of his tomb.[3] The scene represents Rekhmire while he supervises the delivery of *jnw*-contributions to the pharaoh by various groups of foreigners. While similar scenes of delivery of *jnw*-contributions exist in other tombs,[4] the depiction in Rekhmire's tomb stands out, among other things, for the complexity of the composition and the richness of details.[5] The scene

[1] For an overview of the biography of Rekhmire, see Helck, *Zur Verwaltung* (1975), 293–96; Schoske, "Rechmire" (1984); Duhoux, *Des minoens en Egypte?* (2003), 205–208; Bryan, "Administration in the Reign of Thutmose III" (2006), 70–77.

[2] Davies, *Tomb of Rekh-Mi-Rē:* Vols. I and II (1943); Porter and Moss, *Topographical Bibliography* (1960), I 206–14, with references; Den Doncker, *Réactions aux images* (2018), 165–225 with references.

[3] No. 4 on the plan in Porter and Moss, *Topographical Bibliography* (1960), I 208; Den Doncker, *Réactions aux images* (2018), 180–89.

[4] Wachsmann, *Aegeans in the Theban Tombs* (1987); Hallmann, *Die Tributszenen des Neuen Reiches* (2006) with references. On *jnw*, see Bleiberg, *Official Gift* (1996).

[5] Wachsmann, *Aegeans in the Theban Tombs* (1987), 35–37 and passim; Angenot, "Discordance entre texte et image" (2002); Diego Espinel, *Abriendo los caminos de Punt* (2011), 487–88; Güell i Rous, *Tomb of Vizier Rekhmire* (2018).

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is divided into five registers (see Fig. 5). In the top four registers, Egyptians and foreigners are separated by heaps of foreign goods. Various foreigners loaded with goods of every sort, their *jnw*-contributions, can be seen on the left side of these registers. On the right side, instead, Egyptian officials and scribes are shown recording what is being delivered. The fifth register contains no heap of goods between the foreigners and the Egyptian officials. Each register is accompanied by a caption that identifies the foreigners represented in the corresponding register and gives short, mostly formulaic and ideologically-loaded reasons and circumstances for their presence. Each of these captions ends by mentioning Rekhmire's role in supervising the delivery of such *jnw*-contributions. The whole scene is introduced by a descriptive legend (Urk. IV 1094:6-1095:3) that echoes the captions of the single registers in a much-abbreviated form.

Each register of the scene is dedicated to a different group of foreigners. From top to bottom, we have political leaders (i.e., *wrw*)[6] from: the land called *Pwnt*;[7] the land called *Kftjw* and/of[8] the central islands of the sea; the southern foreign countries and the *jwntʸw-stj* of *ḫntʸ-ḥn-nfr*; the land called *Rṯnw* and of all the northern foreign countries of the limits of *Sṯt*. The fifth and last register is conceptually slightly different, as it depicts leaders of both northern and southern countries offering their children as hostages to the Egyptian king.[9] The registers of this scene, and in particular the second one with the Aegean envoys, have attracted considerable attention and have been the object of extensive discussion regarding their general structure and their overall meaning as elements of tomb decorations,[10] as well as the historicity (or lack thereof) of the event and specific peoples represented in it.[11]

The present paper, however, focuses on a striking detail that, it seems, has so far remained unnoticed, namely the fact that the whole captions of the African registers, and parts of those of the other ones, have clear word-by-word parallels in two texts from Hatshepsut's inscriptions about her *Pwnt* expedition found in her temple at Deir el-Bahri.

The Captions of Rekhmire's Scene

The captions that interest us here are those of the first and third registers (for earlier translations, see the works mentioned above). The first register (namely the top one) contains representations of a delegation from the land called *Pwnt*. The text of the caption appears in Table 1.[12] The third register from the top is dedicated to rulers from southern countries. The associated inscription appears in Table 2.

The starting point of this investigation was the observation of a few inconsistencies in the language of these captions. While the overall meaning of the captions is clear, a careful analysis reveals a few linguistic issues here and there. First of all, the sentence in R.I.9 is not grammatical as it stands, since something is clearly missing before the word *mꜣꜥw*—likely either a verb (e.g., *jnj=sn mꜣꜥw*, "(while) they were bringing the gifts …," or the like)[13] or a preposition (e.g., *ḫr mꜣꜥw*, "(while) carrying the gifts …," or the like). Moreover, the expression *n-ꜥꜣt-n bꜣw=f* (R.I.11), "because of the greatness of his Manifestations," raises two questions.

[6] For the translation of *wrw* as "political leaders," I follow the arguments discussed in Kilani, "*tj-nꜣ-y* and *kft(j)w*" (2023). For further discussion of this term, see Matić, "Why Were the Leaders" (2022): 75–77, and Lorton, *Juridical Terminology* (1974), 60–63. Naturally, the use of this term and translation represent the Egyptian point of view, not that of the people of *Pwnt*: we know nothing about how the people from *Pwnt* perceived their political organization and we can hardly expect to learn anything about it from such formulaic Egyptian expressions.

[7] For the use here and below of the expression "land called X" as the most neutral and thus preferable way to translate Egyptian names for such foreign geographical or geopolitical entities, see Kilani, "*tj-nꜣ-y* and *kft(j)w*" (2023): 130–31.

[8] The Egyptian form is syntactically ambiguous.

[9] See Matić, "Children on the Move" (2015) for an overview of depictions of children in tribute scenes.

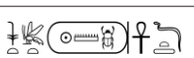
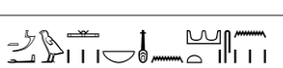
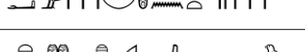
[10] See recently Angenot, "Discordance entre texte et image" (2002); Diego Espinel, *Abriendo los caminos de Punt* (2011), 487–88; Taterka, *Expéditions au Pays de Pount* (2017), 263–64.

[11] See, e.g., Vercoutter, *L'Egypte et le monde égéen préhellénique* (1956); Wachsmann, *Aegeans in the Theban Tombs* (1987); Panagiotopoulos, "Aegeans in Egyptian Tomb Paintings" (2000); Duhoux, *Des minoens en Egypte?* (2003), 11–28; Panagiotopoulos, "Foreigners in Egypt" (2006); Matić, "Out of the Word" (2012); Matić, "'Minoans', *Kftjw* and the 'Islands in the Middle of *Wꜣḏ Wr*'" (2014); Anthony, *Foreigners in Ancient Egypt* (2017); Güell i Rous, *Tomb of Vizier Rekhmire* (2018).

[12] I divide the texts into segments corresponding to clauses or parts of clauses to ease the analysis in the following part of the article. The numeration in the first columns of the tables reflect this and should be read as follows: the rubric "R.I.1," for instance, stands for R = Rekhmire, I = caption of the first register, 1 = first segment.

[13] Breyer, *Punt* (2016), 647, suggests *jjt*, although he translates it as "bringen." This is likely a typo, and we can assume he meant *jnt*, "to bring," as a narrative infinitive.

Table 1—1st register (Urk. IV 1097:7–16).

R.I.1		*jjt m ḥtpw*	Coming in peace
R.I.2		*jn wrw nw*	by the political leaders of
R.I.3		*pwnt*	*Pwnt*
R.I.4		*m [k]sw*	while bowing down
R.I.5		*[m] wȝḥ tp*	and lower[ing] down their heads
R.I.6		*ḫr jnw=sn*	while being under (i.e. = bringing) their *jnw*-contributions
R.I.7		*r ḥw ḫr ḥm=f*	to the place where His Majesty is
R.I.8		*nsw-bityˇ mn-ḫpr-rˁ ˁnḫ ḏt*	the King of Upper and Lower Egypt Menkheperre, may he live forever
R.I.9		*<?> mȝˁw nb(w) nfr(w) n ḫȝst=sn*	(bringing? with?) all the beautiful presents from their country
R.I.10		*tmm ḫnd jn kwˇ*	that has not been trodden by others
R.I.11		*n-ˁȝt-n bȝw[=f] ḫt ḫȝswt=sn*	because [his] Manifestations are across their lands
R.I.12		*jst ḫȝswt nb(w)t m nḏt ḥm=f*	while every foreign country is the servant of His Majesty.
R.I.13		*jn (j)r(ˇ)-pˁ(t) ḥȝtˇ-ˁ mḥ-jb n jtyˇ*	It is the prince, governor, the one who fills the heart of the sovereign
R.I.14		*n nswt ḫntˇ [tȝwˇ*	of the King, who presides over [the Two Lands
R.I.15		*jmˇ-rȝ njwt ṯȝtˇ rḫ mj rˁ]*	the Mayor of the City, *ṯȝtˇ*, Rekhmire]
R.I.16		*šsp jnw nb(w) n ḫȝswt nb(w)t*	who receives all the *jnw*-contributions of all the foreign lands
R.I.17		*jnnw n [bȝw] ḥm=f m nḫtw*	that are brought to/because of the [Manifestations] of His Majesty during/from (his) victories

First, what is the phrase's antecedent? Is it referring to the "Coming of the rulers of the land called *Pwnt*," who arrived to Egypt "because of the greatness of his Manifestations"? Or is it the country, "that has not been trodden by others . . . because of the greatness of his Manifestations"? This latter option certainly sounds less likely, but there is no linguistic reason to exclude it. Obviously, it all depends on who or what that *=f* in *bȝw=f* refers to. One may think it refers to the king, in which case it would likely be the "Coming of the rulers" that is the result of "the greatness of his Manifestations." However, the word *bȝw* appears quite a few times in Rekhmire's scenes, and in all other cases except this one, it is specified by *ḥm=f*; thus, "the Manifestations of his Majesty," not just by *=f*.

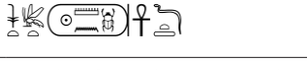
Why this change? A solution for these inconsistences is provided by two texts from the expedition to *Pwnt* by Hatshepsut at Deir el-Bahri, where we can find remarkable parallels for the captions of Rekhmire's African registers.

Intertextual Parallels between Rekhmire's and Hatshepsut's Inscriptions

Precise word-to-word parallels for these captions can be found in three passages (here called A, Ba, and Bb) of Hatshepsut's inscriptions in the colonnade of her temple at Deir el-Bahri.[14] They are discussed in the following sections.

[14] Titled respectively "K. Die Königin empfängt die Beute der Expedition und nimmt die Huldigung der mitgeführten Häuptlinge

Table 2—3rd register (Urk. IV 1100:1–9).

R.III.1		*jjt m ḫtpw*	Coming in peace
R.III.2		*jn wrw nw*	by the political leaders of
R.III.3		*ḫ3swt rs(y)t*	the southern foreign countries
R.III.4		*jwntyw-stj nw ḫntyw-ḫm-nfr*	the *jwntyw-stj* of *ḫntyw-ḫm-nfr*
R.III.5		*m ksw*	while bowing down,
R.III.6		*ḫr dḥn t3*	the (forehead) touching the ground,
R.III.7		*ḫr jnw=sn*	while being under (i.e. = bringing) their *jnw*-contributions
R.III.8		*[r bw ḫr ḫm=f]*	[to the place under His Majesty (i.e.: where His majesty is)]
R.III.9		*nsw-bity mn-ḫpr-rꜥ ꜥnḫ ḏt*	the King of Upper and Lower Egypt Menkheperre, may he live forever,
R.III.10		*sb=tw*[a] *rdjt n=sn ṯ3w n ꜥnḫ*	in order that the breath of life is given to them
R.III.11		*jn (j)r(y)-pꜥt ḫ3ty-ꜥ ḫtm(w)-bjty smr wꜥ(ty)*	It is the Prince, Governor, Seal-Bearer of the King of Lower Egypt, sole friend
R.III.12		*jmy-r3 njwt ṯ3ty rḫ mj rꜥ*	Mayor of the City, *ṯ3ty*, Rekhmire,
R.III.13		*šsp jnw n ḫ3swt nb(w)t*	who receives the *jnw*-contributions of all foreign countries
R.III.14		*jnnw n b3w n ḫm=f*	that are brought to/because of the Manifestations of His Majesty
R.III.15		*m pḫtyw […]*	through force […]
R.III.16		*mnḫ=f mj rꜥ […]*	his efficiency like Re […]

[a] The translation "in order (that)" follows the TLA, ID 131670. See also Gardiner, *Egyptian Grammar* (1957), 136, who suggests the translation "in quest of."

Passage A

The context of Passage A in Hatshepsut's inscriptions is particularly interesting, since it comes from a text describing the bringing of *jnw*-contributions by emissaries from *Pwnt* and from other southern countries. This text is also associated with a figurative representation of these emissaries. Even though part of it is now destroyed, it is still possible to see that the foreign envoys were organized in two registers: those from *Pwnt* occupying the bottom one, and those from the southern countries occupying the top one.[15] The thematic similarity between this scene and those of Rekhmire is obvious; this aspect is further discussed below. As for the passage itself, it is reproduced in Table 3.[16]

entgegen–2. Inschrift vor den Häuptlingen, die vor den Namen der Königin knieen" and "N. Die Königin vor Amon–1. Inschrift der Königin" in Sethe and Helck, *Urkunden des ägyptischen Altertums*, IV (1906–1961).

[15] For a recent description and discussion see Taterka, *Expéditions au Pays de Pount* (2017), 192–94, with references, and "Hatshepsut's Punt Reliefs" (2019). Also relevant are Taterka's other works, including "Secretary Bird" (2019), "Mysterious Wooden Objects" (2021), and "Intriguing Inscription" (2023).

[16] Similar to above (see n. 12), the code in the first column should be read as follows: "H.A.1" stands for H = Hatshepsut, A = text A, 1 = first segment.

Passages Ba+Bb

Passages Ba and Bb come from the section of the inscriptions describing the oracle-like announcement by Amun of the yet-to-occur expedition to *Pwnt* organized by Hatshepsut.[17] In contrast with Passage A, this inscription presents no obvious thematic or formal connections with the captions of Rekhmire. It is also worth mentioning that the whole text was erased in antiquity,[18] a destruction that is usually attributed to the will of Thutmose III.[19] This aspect will be further discussed below. The relevant lines are reproduced in Tables 4a and 4b.[20]

Differences Between the Rekhmire and Hatshepsut Inscriptions

It is clear that the captions of the scene of Rekhmire have been composed by combining bits and pieces from Hatshepsut's inscriptions, or from a common source. In fact, excluding the clauses with the name of Thutmose III and the final clauses mentioning Rekhmire's titles and role as the supervisor of the bringing of the *jnw*-contributions, nearly all of the clauses that make up these captions have a direct parallel in one (and in some cases two) of the passages of Hatshepsut's inscriptions (see Table 5). Moreover, it is significant that while some of these expressions are formulaic and can thus be occasionally found also in other contemporary texts,[21] others seem to be quite rare and non-formulaic, or even unique to these texts. Moreover, only the texts of Hatshepsut present parallels for almost all of the expressions used in these captions of Rekhmire. This clearly supports the idea of a direct link between these two compositions that goes beyond a mere shared use of generic and widespread formulaic expressions. Yet while the connection between these texts is evident, there are also some small but interesting differences.

Differences in Spelling

While the clauses of Rekhmire's African captions have word-to-word parallels in Hatshepsut's texts, there are differences in the spelling of several words. This strongly suggests that Rekhmire's clauses were not blindly copied sign by sign from Hatshepsut's texts. Rather, the differences may reflect re-editing by the scribe(s) of Rekhmire (for aesthetic purposes and/or to adapt them to the space and context of Rekhmire's scene?), or a partially oral process involving dictation rather than visual copying at some point in the transmission chain, or the use of a third document that was related to, but at least orthographically distinct from, Hatshepsut's inscriptions.

Differences in Pronouns

At the linguistic level, the main divergence between the texts of Hatshepsut and those of Rekhmire concerns the pronouns. First, Rekhmire's captions use *ḥm=f*, "his majesty" (R.I.7/R.III.8), whereas Hatshepsut's uses *ḥmt=s*, "her majesty" (H.A.12). This is a rather trivial change, obviously related to the fact that Rekhmire is referring to Thutmose III. Then there is Rekhmire's *bȝw=f* (R.I.11) for Hatshepsut's *bȝw=t* (H.Bb.9). Here again, the change can be explained as an adaptation to a different narrative frame: in Hatshepsut's text, it is Hatshepsut's *bȝw* that is being mentioned, so the feminine second person pronoun *=t* is used. In Rekhmire's text, by contrast, none of the people involved are talking directly with anyone. A second-person pronoun would thus be out of place here, and even more so a feminine one. The question remains, however: to whom does the *=f* of Rekhmire's text refer? If the scribe was calquing the text of Hatshepsut, then the *=f* could refer to the king, and in turn the clause could refer to the rulers of *Pwnt*, who came "because his (= the king's) power is across their lands." By contrast, if the scribe was reinterpreting the texts he was copying, then *=f* might (implicitly) refer to a god, likely Amun. If so, the whole clause should refer to the immediately previous one (i.e., *tmm ḫnd jn kwy*) and should probably be understood as "their country that has not been trodden by others because his (= Amun's) power is across their lands." I find the first interpretation preferable, because it follows Hatshepsut's text. From a strictly linguistic perspective, I see no reason to exclude the latter option. However, as one of the anonymous reviewers rightly pointed out, there appear to be no clear parallels to the idea that a god's *bȝw* might prevent people from

[17] For a recent description see Taterka, *Expéditions au Pays de Pount* (2017), 214–16, with references, and "Hatshepsut's Punt Reliefs" (2019).

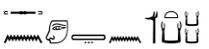
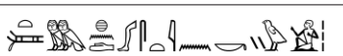
[18] Naville, *Temple of Deir El Bahari*—Part 3 (1895), 18. Even though the text was erased, enough traces remain to make most of it readable—therefore, only the parts that are truly lost will be marked with [ ] in the present article.

[19] On the proscription of Hatshepsut, see, e.g., Roehrig, Dreyfus, and Keller, *Hatshepsut, from Queen to Pharaoh* (2005); on this specific instance, see, e.g., Taterka, *Expéditions au Pays de Pount* (2017), 214.

[20] See also *ibid.,* 214–15.

[21] This is the case, for instance, for the segments describing *wrw* bringing *jnw*-contributions.

Table 3—Passage A from Hatshepsut's inscriptions (Urk. IV 331.3–14).[a]

H.A.1		*[ ]*	[ ]
H.A.2		*sn t3 n wsrt k3w*	Kissing the ground for *Wsrt-K3w*
H.A.3		*jn wrw nw*	by the political leaders of
H.A.4		*pwnt*	the land called *Pwnt*
H.A.5		*[ ]*	[ ]
H.A.6		*jwntʸw-stj nw ḫntʸ-ḫn-nfr*	the *jwntʸw-stj* of *ḫntʸ-ḫn-nfr*
H.A.7		*ḫ3st nbt rsʸ(wt)*	every foreign country of the south
H.A.8		*nw kmt*	of Egypt
H.A.9		*[m ks]w*	[while bowing down]
H.A.10		*m w3ḥ tp*	and lowering down their heads
H.A.11		*ḥr jnw=sn*	while being under (i.e., bringing) their *jnw*-contributions
H.A.12		*r b(w) ḥr ḫmt=s*	to the place under Her Majesty (i.e.: where her majesty is)
H.A.13		*[… ḥr] w3wt*	[ ] on the ways
H.A.14		*tmm ḫnd=st*[b] *jn kwʸ*	that have not been trodden by others
H.A.15		*[ ]*	[ ]
H.A.16		*ḫ3st nbt m nḏt nt ḫmt=s*	every foreign country is the servant of Her Majesty.

[a] See also Taterka, *Expéditions au Pays de Pount* (2017), 192.

[b] One of the anonymous reviewers suggested to read this *st* as a dependent pronoun rather than as a suffix pronoun, but I disagree. First, it would be grammatically unusual to have a dependent pronoun after the infinitive *ḫnd*. Second, and more important, in another passage from the inscriptions of Hatshepsut (Urk IV 344:7) we find *t3 nṯr tmm ḫnd*=f: "the god's land that have not been trodden," which confirms we are dealing here with a suffix pronoun, as =f cannot be a dependant pronoun. By contrast, the reviewer's observation that we would expect a feminine *-t* after tmm is valid, as indeed tmm seems to be a participle referring to *w3wt*. I see only two solutions, which to me look equally possible: either this is a scribal error and the -t was indeed forgotten by the scribe (possibly under the influence of a passage where the antecedent was masculine, as in Urk IV 344:7), or tmm is not a participle to begin with. In this case, it might perhaps be a reduplicated nominal form with a temporal meaning (so something like "when the treading of them [= the ways] by others had not occurred yet"), somehow analogous the use of non-reduplicated tm in temporal clauses attested elsewhere; see Gardiner, *Egyptian Grammar* (1957), 265.

entering a foreign land. This absence does not render the second interpretation impossible, but it certainly makes it less compelling. The question, therefore, remains open.

One can also observe that Hatshepsut's *ḫ3st ṯn* (H.Bb.4) has been replaced with Rekhmire's *ḫ3st=sn* (R.I.9), which indeed makes more sense in his text. In addition, in R.I.10 of Rekhmire, the pronoun *st* has been omitted, while in R.I.11 the pronoun *=sn* has been added. The latter variations are hard to explain, as I do not see any obvious reasons why Rekhmire's scribe(s) might have felt the need to change these elements. This is an intriguing issue that will be further discussed below.

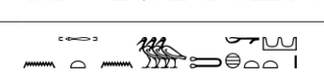
Clauses without Parallels

While most of the clauses that compose Rekhmire's captions can be found in Hatshepsut texts, some of them

Table 4a—Passage Ba from Hatshepsut's inscriptions (Urk. IV 341:16–342:2).

H.Ba.1		*jw=sn n=s*	May they come to her
H.Ba.2		*m jb snḏ*	with fearful heart
H.Ba.3		*ḫrʸw-tp=sn*	their chiefs
H.Ba.4		*m wȝḫ tp*	lowering down the head
H.Ba.5		*mȝᶜw=sn ḫr psḏ=sn*	(while) their gifts are on their back
H.Ba.6		*ḫnk=sn n=s m msw=sn*	and they present to her their children
H.Ba.7		*sḫ=tw (4) rdjt n=sn ṯȝw n ᶜnḫ*	in order to be given the breath of life
H.Ba.8		*n-ᶜȝt bȝw*	because of the greatness of the Manifestations
H.Ba.9		*jt[=s] jmn*	of [her] father Amun
H.Ba.10		*rdj tȝw nbw ḫr ṯbtʸ=s*	who places all foreign land under her sandals.

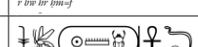
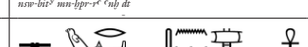
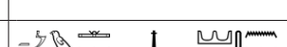
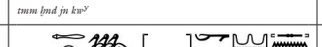
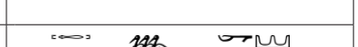
Table 4b—Passage Bb from Hatshepsut's inscriptions (Urk. IV 345:11–346:2).

H.Bb.1		*ȝtp=sn ᶜḥᶜw*	May they load ships
H.Bb.2		*r ḥtpt jb=sn*	to the satisfaction of their heart
H.Bb.3		*m nhwt nt ᶜntʸw wȝḏ*	with trees of fresh myrrh
H.Bb.4		*mȝᶜw nb nfr n ḫȝst ṯn*	and all good products of this foreign country.
H.Bb.5		*pwntʸw ḫm rmṯ*	Those-of-*Pwnt* unknown to men
H.Bb.6		*ḫbstʸw nw tȝ-nṯr*	The Bearded Ones of the God's Land,
H.Bb.7		*sjmȝ~n(=j) st m mrt=t*	I have placated them out of love of you (fem. so: Hatshepsut's).
H.Bb.8		*dj=sn n=t jȝw mj nṯr*	May they give praise to you (fem. so: Hatshepsut's) like a god
H.Bb.9		*n-[ᶜȝ]t-n bȝw=ṯ ḫt ḫȝst*	because of the [great]ness of your (fem. so: Hatshepsut's) Manifestations throughout the foreign country.

(R.I.1/R.III.1, R.I.8/R.III.9, R.III.6) seem to have no parallel there. In one case, the reason is quite evident: the clauses R.I.8/R.III.9 consist of the royal name of Thutmose III, which obviously could not have been part of Hatshepsut's inscriptions and was certainly added by the scribe(s) who composed these captions.

The very first clauses of both registers, namely *jjt m ḥtpw*, "Coming in peace" (R.I.1/R.III.1), also has no parallel in the extant texts of Hatshepsut. However, the very beginning of Text A of Hatshepsut is lost in a lacuna, and reconstructing here *jjt m ḥtpw* would make sense in light of the following two clauses, as it would provide a good context for the *sn tȝ n wsrt kȝw*, "Kissing the ground for *Wsrt-Kȝw*" of clause H.A.2, and would be the action performed *jn wrw nw pwnt*, "by the political leaders of the land called *Pwnt*" of clauses H.A.3–4. If this were correct, then these initial

Table 5—Comparison between Rekhmire's captions and the passages from Hatshepsut's inscriptions.

Rekhmire				**Hatshepsut**			
1st Register		**3rd Register**		**Passage A**		**Passage B**	
R.I.1	 *jjt m ḫtpw*	R.III.1	 *jjt m ḫtpw*				
R.I.2	 *jn wrw nw*	R.III.2	 *jn wrw nw*	H.A.3	 *jn wrw nw*		
R.I.3	 *pwnt*			H.A.4	 *pwnt*		
		R.III.3	 *ḫḳꜣwt rs(ỉ)t*	H.A.7	 *ḫḳꜣt nbt rsỉ(wt)*		
		R.III.4	 *jwntỉw-stj nw ḫntỉ-ḥm-nfr*	H.A.6	 *jwntỉw-stj nw ḫntỉ-ḥm-nfr*		
R.I.4	 *m [ḳ]ꜣw*	R.III.5	 *m ḳꜣw*	H.A.9	 *[m ḳs]w*		
R.I.5	 *[m] wšḫ ỉẖ*			H.A.10	 *m wšḫ ỉẖ*	H.Ba.4	 *m wšḫ ỉẖ*
		R.III.6	 *ḫr dḏm ỉꜣ*				
R.I.6	 *ḫr jnw=sn*	R.III.7	 *ḫr jnw=sn*	H.A.11	 *ḫr jnw=sn*		
R.I.7	 *r ḫw ḫr ḫm=f*	R.III.8	 *[r ḫw ḫr ḫm=f]*	H.A.12	 *r ḫw ḫr ḫmt=s*		
R.I.8	 *nsw-biỉ nwy-ḫpr-rꜥ ꜥnḫ dt*	R.III.9	 *nsw-biỉ nwy-ḫpr-rꜥ ꜥnḫ dt*				
		R.III.10	 *sḏ=tw rdỉt n=sn tꜣw n ꜥnḫ*			H.Ba.7	 *sḏ=tw rdỉt n=sn tꜣw n ꜥnḫ*
R.I.9	 *mꜣꜥw nb(w) nfr(w) n ḫḳt=sn*					H.Bb.4	 *mꜣꜥw nb(w) nfr(w) n ḫḳt tn*
R.I.10	 *tmm ḫnd jn kwy*			H.A.13	 *tmm ḫnd=st jn kwy*		
R.I.11	 *n-ꜥꜣt-n bꜣw[=f] ỉẖt ḫḳwt=sn*					H.Bb.9	 *n-ỉ[ꜥ]t-n bꜣw=t ỉẖt ḫḳt*
R.I.12	 *jst ḫḳwt nb(w)t m ndt ḫm=f*			H.A.15	 *ḫḳt nbt m ndt nt ḫmt=s*		

clauses of Rekhmire's captions would also have been taken from Hatshepsut's inscriptions. Finally, also Rekhmire's clause R.III.6 (*ḫr dḥn tȝ*, "the [forehead] touching the ground") has no parallel in Hatshepsut's texts. While this could certainly be an innovation introduced by Rekhmire's scribe(s), we cannot exclude that this clause might have had a parallel in Hatshepsut's texts now lost in one of the several lacunae (perhaps in the lacuna in H.A.9).

Differences in the Organization of the Clauses

Finally, Rekhmire's captions also differ from Hatshepsut's inscriptions in the organization of the single clauses. On the one hand, we see that the order of some clauses is reversed (R.III.3–R.III.4 = H.A.7–H.A.6). The reason for this reversal is unclear to me, as I see no significant improvement for the meaning of the text. On the other hand, clauses from different passages of Hatshepsut's inscriptions are taken out of their contexts and recombined within a single caption in Rekhmire's scene.[22] This is clearly the case of the four clauses R.I.9–12 in the caption of the first register, where two clauses from Hatshepsut's Passage Bb (H.Bb.4, H.Bb.9) alternate with two clauses from Hatshepsut's Passage A (H.A.13, H.A.15).

And here we see something interesting: while the overall meaning of the resulting text makes sense, and while the scribe(s) did change some of the pronouns to make them compatible with the new context, it is also clear that the grammar of the resulting patchwork text is slightly off. As mentioned above, the use of *mȝᶜw* at the beginning of clause R.I.9 is hardly grammatical, while its use in Hatshepsut's text—as the circumstantial clause of the initial *jw=sn n=s*, "May they come to her"—is grammatically correct. Similarly, the use of the clause *n-ᶜȝt-n bȝw=f ḫȝswt=sn*, "because his power is across their lands" (R.I.11), is bizarre: the general idea the scribe(s) wanted to express by putting this clause here is easy to grasp, but the specific semantic and grammatical connections of this clause with those around it are clearly off base.

[22] It is worth mentioning here that conceptually comparable recompositions have been observed also in cases of pictorial intericonicity, in which elements from earlier representations were modified and recombined in later, novel compositions; see, e.g., Den Doncker, "Theban Tomb Graffiti" (2012), 31; Laboury, "Tradition and Creativity" (2017).

Discussion

These differences raise interesting questions about the processes underlying the composition of these captions. First of all, it is clear that these clauses went through some form of editing that involved changes to specific simple grammatical elements (especially pronouns) to make them generally fit with the new context of the captions. At the same time, however, whoever composed these captions did not fix the more subtle (or more advanced) grammatical inconsistencies resulting from their patchwork.

I believe we can suggest two possible explanations for these observations. The first possibility is to assume that the captions of Rekhmire were composed by one or more scribes who had access to the texts of Hatshepsut (or to a copy of some kind), as well as enough understanding of Middle Egyptian to adapt basic features like the pronouns to the new context, but who did not bother (or did not have the needed linguistic expertise in Middle Egyptian) to fix more subtle issues involving more advanced grammatical elements.

Alternatively, it is worth noticing that none of the clauses attested in Rekhmire specifically and unambiguously refers to Hatshepsut or to Hatshepsut's expedition. They can be linked with Hatshepsut's inscriptions because of their unique phrasing, but at the level of the content, they are rather general sentences that in principle could have been used also by other kings in other contexts. Therefore, one could also assume that both the texts of Hatshepsut and the captions of Rekhmire have been copied from a third, lost document (or a copy of it), which should then predate the texts of Hatshepsut. Such a hypothetical document might have been composed for Hatshepsut herself, or might have been composed for one of her predecessors. In the latter case, we could imagine that this hypothetical prototype was written for a male king and thus used masculine pronouns. If so, we could also imagine that it was the scribe(s) of Hatshepsut who edited the text introducing the feminine pronouns, while the scribe(s) of Rekhmire simply extracted the necessary clauses from such a hypothetical masculine prototype without altering them. This second explanation would have the advantage that we would not need to assume the work of scribe(s) who could correct pronouns but not verbs: we could assume that all changes were made by the scribes of Hatshepsut when they adapted the clauses from the hypothetical masculine prototype to the needs of their ruler, while the scribe(s) of Rekhmire simply made a

patchwork of clauses without reworking them, as they were already used in a prototype with masculine pronouns. At the moment I do not see any objective way to choose between these two options, but future evidence might clarify this point.

Something, however, could be said about the general phenomenon underlying what has just been described. Intertextuality between inscriptions is not, in fact, unique to the tomb of Rekhmire in the 18th dynasty. Rather the opposite: scholars have long observed that the artists and scribes working in the tombs of the time formed a very complex social network that allowed for the circulation and reproduction of textual and iconographic elements across monuments, including private tombs.[23] This intertextuality and intericonicity involved both royal and non-royal monuments, including private tombs contemporaneous with Rekhmire's, and Hatshepsut's mortuary temple.[24] Of particular interest for us here is the case of the tomb of Puyemre (TT 39), where already Norman de Garis Davies noticed the presence of an offering list incorporating a Coffin Text spell (CT 607) and a text derived from the Pyramid Texts that had a very close parallel in Hatshepsut's Chapel.[25] Yet, while the Pyramid Text of Puyemre appears to be identical with that of Hatshepsut, his CT spell appears to derive from a different (and according to Davies, "less trustworthy") copy. This means that Puyemre's tomb attests to a whole range of intertextuality. First we have copying in a private tomb from Hatshepsut's monuments or a very close version of the same texts (i.e., the Pyramid Text excerpt and the offering list itself). Then there is the reproduction in a private tomb of a text attested in Hatshepsut's monuments, but in a form that points to a distinct source (i.e., the Coffin Text spell). In addition, no matter what the relation between Hatshepsut's and Puyemre's texts are, neither is an original composition; rather, both ultimately derive from (much) earlier sources.

Speaking generally, Middle and Old Kingdom textual and iconographic models seem to have been a recurrent source of inspiration for 18th dynasty artists, as has been observed by previous scholars. Francis Breyer, for instance, suggested that the whole inscription of the Punt Expedition derived from an earlier (and so far unattested) Old Kingdom prototype.[26] If Breyer were right, this would be relevant for the present article, since the passages discussed here do come from that very inscription. However, his hypothesis has to be taken with caution, as some of his arguments are questionable,[27] and his theory is unlikely to be true for the whole composition, as he claims, since there are some passages containing elements that, based on our current knowledge, unequivocally point to a New Kingdom moment of composition.[28] Interestingly, this seems to be the case also for some of the passages discussed in this article, as the language of the captions and thus that of Hatshepsut texts present at least one expression (*sb=tw*, "in order that") which, according to the TLA,[29] is attested primarily in the New Kingdom[30] and in later periods. This suggests that the origin of the source text (whether it is Hatshepsut's texts, or

[23] See Kahl, *Siut-Theben* (1999); Laboury, "Le scribe et le peintre" (2016) and "Tradition and Creativity" (2017). On intertextuality in Egyptian literature in general, see Loprieno, "Defining Egyptian Literature" (1996), 51–52.

[24] See, e.g., Hays and Schenck, "Intersection of Ritual Space" (2007); Dorman and Bryan, *Sacred Space* (2007); Jasper, "Will the Hunger Be Repelled" (2017); Den Doncker, "Identifying-Copies in the Private Theban Necropolis" (2017); Stupko-Lubczyńska, "What an Artist Saw" (2021).

[25] Davies, *Tomb of Puyemrê*. Vol II (1923), 10 n. 3; see also, more recently, Stupko-Lubczyńska, "Chapel of Hatshepsut" (2013).

[26] Breyer, "Vorlagen zur ›Punthalle‹" (2014).

[27] For instance, the use of archaic-looking forms for some glyphs does not imply that the text itself was copied from a much earlier source (*ibid.*: 68–69), as several cultures preserved or developed archaic-looking forms for their scripts to be used as specific calligraphic styles or in culturally marked contexts. For instance, one can think of the use of Seal Script in China, of the Kufic style in the Arabic world, of the Grantha in Southern India, or even the use of medieval calligraphic styles in postmedieval Europe, used until today.

[28] For instance, the names of the rulers of Punt are clearly written in New Kingdom Group Writing, an orthography that is usually assumed to have emerged not earlier than the (late) Second Intermediate Period, and which became common only during the New Kingdom: Kilani, "Group Writing" (2023).

[29] See the Lemma-ID 131670, and the attestations in the legacy website, using "guest" as user name and password to access: https://aaew.bbaw.de/tla/servlet/DzaBrowser?u=guest&f=0&l=0&wn=131670, accessed December 2025.

[30] As pointed out by one of the anonymous reviewers, two of the occurrences of *sb=tw in TLA* come from the *Teaching of Merikare*, a text generally assumed to date to the Middle Kingdom, even though the surviving manuscripts are from the 18th Dynasty. However, it should be noted that both instances appear to rely exclusively on Helck's reconstruction of the word in *Lehre für König Merikare* (1977), 7, 9. As such, they cannot be considered strong evidence for a pre-New Kingdom occurrence. Nonetheless, this reconstruction seems to be widely accepted—not only by the TLA, but also by scholars such as Quack, e.g. *Zerstörung von geschriebenem historische und transkulturelle Perspektiven* (2019), 48.

something preceding them), should not be sought before the New Kingdom, at least as long as there is no attestation of this expression in earlier sources.

Therefore, to summarize: while Breyer might be right in thinking that *some* elements of Hatshepsut's Punt Expedition inscriptions might have been copied or inspired from much earlier Old or Middle Kingdom sources; and while, as Puyemre's tomb attests, it is certainly possible that both Rekhmire's captions and Hatshepsut's corresponding passages were copied or inspired by one or more earlier compositions; this still does not mean that Rekhmire's captions must be derived from unattested Old/Middle Kingdom prototypes. In fact, the use of the expression *sb=tw* rather suggests that, if a common prototype existed, it was likely a New Kingdom source.

Iconographic Similarities

While Passages Ba and Bb do not appear to have any thematic connection with Rekhmire's scene, Hatshepsut's Passage A appears with a scene of bringing *jnw*-contributions comparable to that of Rekhmire. What is remarkable is that the iconographic parallels between Rekhmire's and Hatshepsut's scenes extend beyond mere thematic similarity, involving specific elements and forms that can hardly be considered accidental. To be clear: Hatshepsut's and Rekhmire's *Pwnt* and southern countries registers are not identical, neither in their composition nor in the details of their individual elements. It is enough to look at the clearly different ways in which the clothes of the people of *Pwnt* are represented in the two scenes to see that Rekhmire is not just a simple copy of Hatshepsut's scene. However, at the same time, a series of specific elements in Rekhmire's scenes, in spite of differences in the details, are suspiciously reminiscent of Hatshepsut's scenes.[31] These similarities are presented in Figures 1–5.[32]

As in the case of the captions, while the overall organization is different, and while specific details have been altered, it is clear that the scenes of Rekhmire are not completely original, but rather the result of a patchwork of slightly modified elements already attested in Hatshepsut's scenes.[33]

It has to be noted here that, as already observed by Shelley Wachsmann, some of the elements of Rekhmire's registers also appear (again with similar forms, but often different details) in other scenes of the bringing of *jnw*-contributions in later monuments. In particular, Wachsmann noticed that the combination of bulls and a giraffe can be found also in the scenes of the tomb of Huy,[34] while the hunting dogs, the bulls, the giraffe, the fawn, two monkeys, and the leopard, which are all attested in Rekhmire's register, can be found in a tribute/victory scene in Ramses II's temple at Beit el-Wali.

The nature and origins of these parallels need attention. Wachsmann is convinced that these similarities reflect the use by different artists in different periods of common pattern books, which provided guidelines about specific subjects that could be used to compose thematically similar scenes. Each artist would have then modified specific details in their respective scenes. Yet, according to Wachsmann, the similarity between the elements appearing in the scenes of Rekhmire, Huy, and of the temple of Beit el-Wali—along with the comparable order in which they are organized—point to a connection between these scenes that goes beyond a vague collection of common templates, and rather points to a "same source."[35] To be fair, if it were only for these elements and their ordering, one might wonder about this latter suggestion. While their formal similarities clearly point to a shared common set of forms, possibly derived from pattern books, their selection and ordering might simply reflect a historical reality: in principle, one could imagine that these products were genuinely coveted by the Egyptian kings and thus were truly delivered multiple times throughout the New Kingdom, and they might have been presented according to a specific, recurrent ordering during the public events represented in these scenes.

This possibility and related issues have been discussed by various scholars after Wachsmann, who have pointed out how frequent, widespread, and complex such iconographic connections, interpretations, and

[31] See also Den Doncker, *Réactions aux images* (2018), 177, 186–87.

[32] See also Taterka, "Mysterious Wooden Objects" (2021) for other potential similarities.

[33] This similarity has been independently noticed also by Alexis Den Doncker, who discussed it in his unpublished thesis *Réactions aux images* (2018), 177, 186–87. The numerous parallels collected by Anastasiia Stupko-Lubczyńska in her book *Offering Scenes* (2016) suggest that a similar phenomenon can be observed in the temple of Hatshepsut itself, where the offering scenes represented in the Chapel of Hatshepsut appear to be inspired by various Old and Middle Kingdom examples, even though no single source can be pinpointed as being the Vorlage. There as well, Hatshepsut's artists seem to have used a patchwork of various earlier monuments.

[34] Wachsmann, *Aegeans in the Theban Tombs* (1987), 47.

[35] *Ibid.*, 47–48.

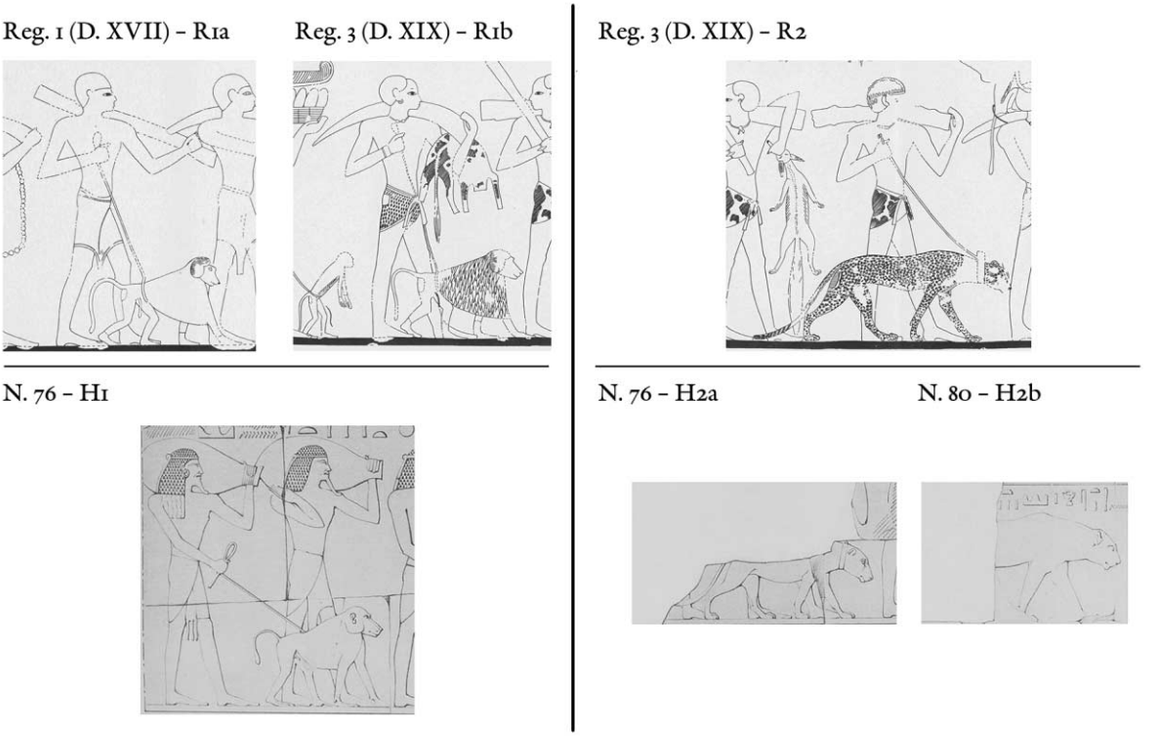


Figure 1—Iconographic parallels between the scenes of Rekhmire's tomb and those of Hatshepsut's temple.[a]
[a] D. = plates from Davies, *Tomb of Rekh-Mi-Rē: Vol II* (1943); N. = plates from Naville, *Temple of Deir El Bahari - Part. 3* (1895).

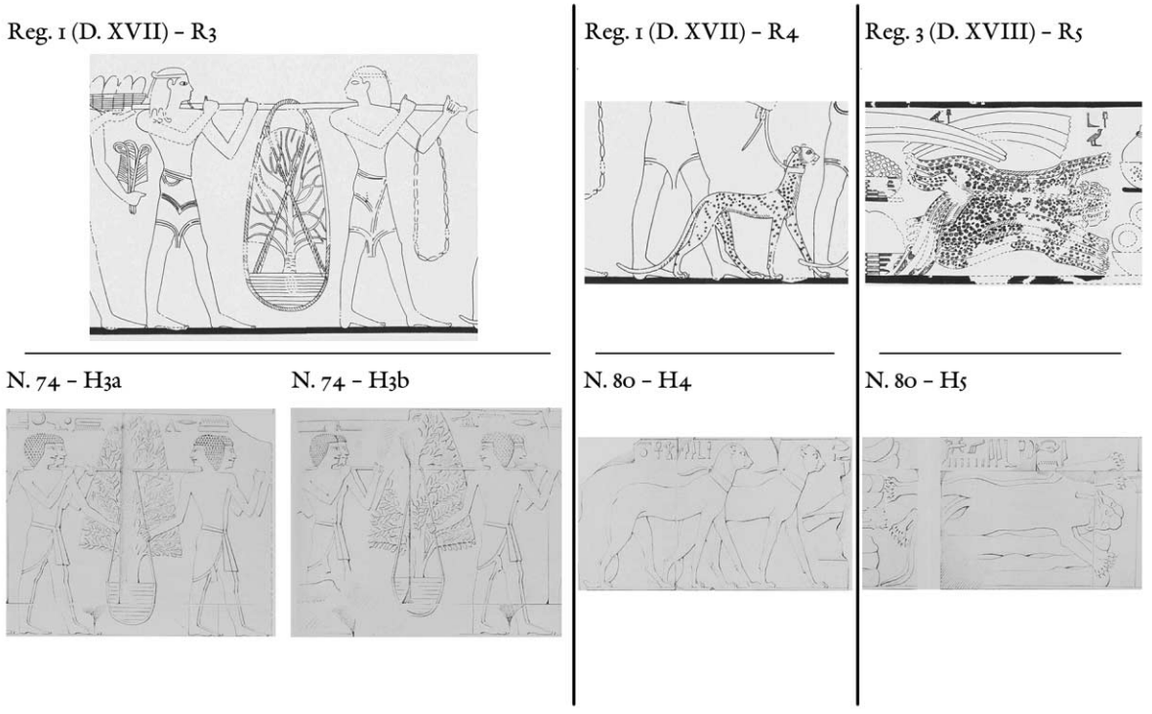


Figure 2—Iconographic parallels between the scenes of Rekhmire's tomb and those of Hatshepsut's temple.[a]
[a] D. = plates from Davies, *Tomb of Rekh-Mi-Rē: Vol II* (1943); N. = plates from Naville, *Temple of Deir El Bahari - Part. 3* (1895).

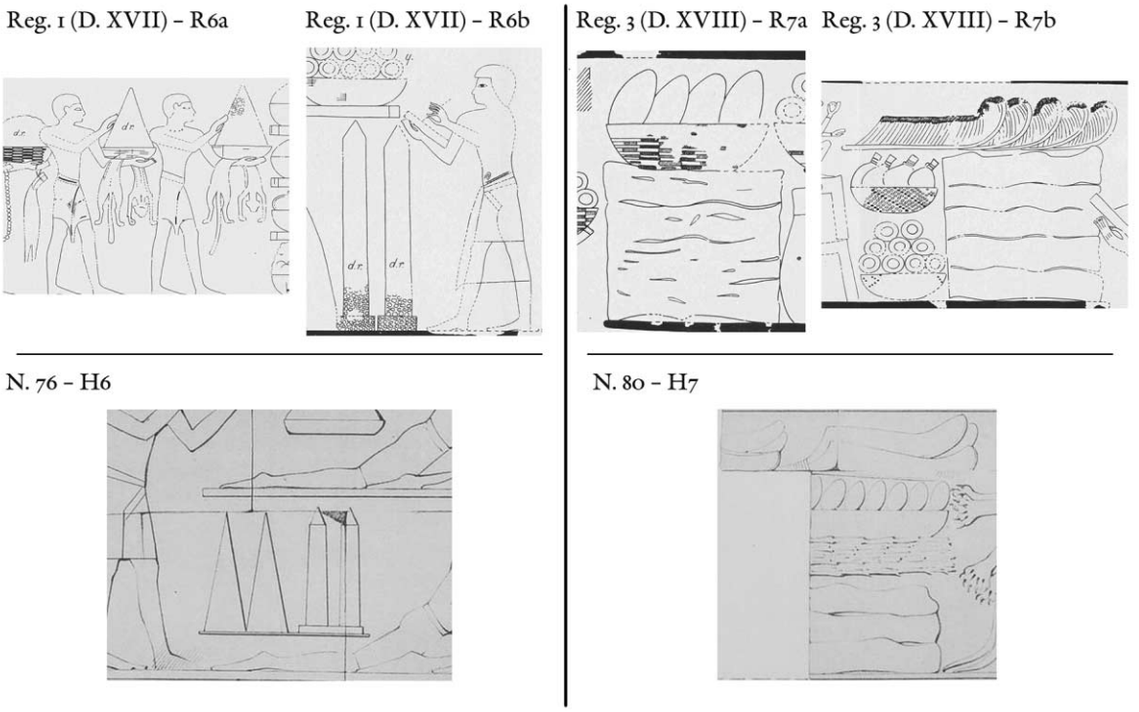


Figure 3—Iconographic parallels between the scenes of Rekhmire's tomb and those of Hatshepsut's temple.[a]
[a] D. = plates from Davies, *Tomb of Rekh-Mi-Rē: Vol II* (1943); N. = plates from Naville, *Temple of Deir El Bahari - Part. 3* (1895).

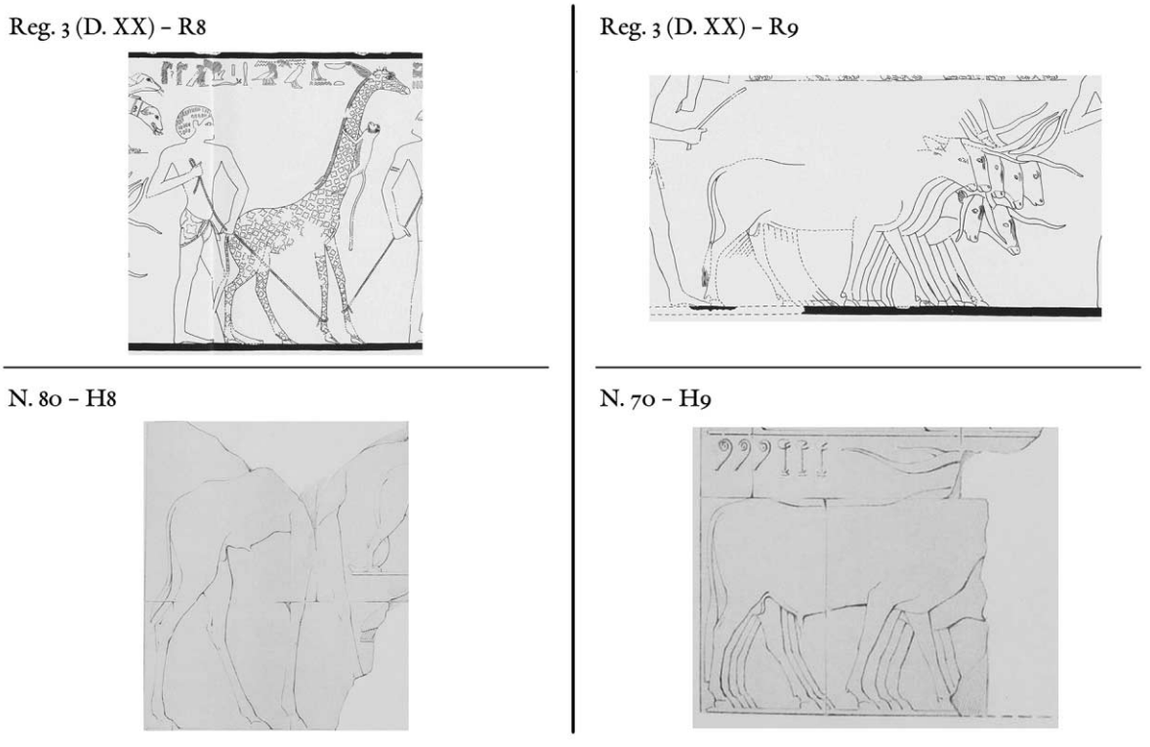


Figure 4—Iconographic parallels between the scenes of Rekhmire's tomb and those of Hatshepsut's temple.[a]
[a] D. = plates from Davies, *Tomb of Rekh-Mi-Rē: Vol II* (1943); N. = plates from Naville, *Temple of Deir El Bahari - Part. 3* (1895).

visual dialogues are, and how integral intericonicity is to the Egyptian art of the period in general.[36] The parallels between the scene of Rekhmire and those of Hatshepsut fit well within this general picture, but they also add an additional piece to the puzzle, as the clear link between the captions of the former and the texts of the latter suggests a stronger connection that goes beyond the mere circulation and reuse of basic forms among artists. Such parallels at the iconographic *and* textual level, with such word-to-word correspondences, point to a more specific relation, and an even more complex reality.

Here again we can wonder about the underlying processes: should we assume that the artists and scribes who planned the scenes of Rekhmire took direct inspiration from the depictions and texts of Hatshepsut, and recombined and reworked them according to their own original taste? Or should we assume that both the artists and scribes of Hatshepsut and those of Rekhmire based their representations on a third distinct and now-lost model? And if so, who modified what? Did the artist(s) and scribe(s) of Rekhmire precisely copy such a hypothetical model, while the artists of Hatshepsut departed from it, adding original details and adapting the language according to the needs of their context? Or should we assume the opposite? Alternatively, could it be that the artists and scribes of both Hatshepsut and Rekhmire based their work on such a model but departed from it by adding their own original and distinct details? These questions, which have already been asked by several scholars working on the circulation of artistic motifs,[37] go well beyond the scope of this article; they are, however, crucial to appreciate the complexity of the underlying reality.

Intertextuality with the Other Registers

As said at the beginning, the emissaries from the land called *Pwnt* and those from southern countries occupy only two of the five registers of Rekhmire's tribute scene. The other three registers are occupied by the people of the land called *Kftjw*, by the people of the land called *Rṯnw*, and by generic northern and southern foreigners. As in the case of the two registers discussed above, these other three registers have their own captions. The clauses of these three additional captions can be divided into two groups.

First, some of these captions are unique and provide specific details that are uniquely linked to the people represented in the associated register. For instance, the second and third clauses of the second registers are *jn wrw nw kftjw | jww ḫrʸ-jb nw wȝḏ-wr*, "by the political leaders of the land called *Kftjw* and/of the central islands of the sea," thus providing the identity of the people represented in the associated register. I could not find any exact parallel for any of these clauses, neither in the texts of Hatshepsut, nor in those of any other king. They seem to me to be unique to the tomb of Rekhmire (but of course, I would be glad to be proved wrong here).

Second, other clauses instead contain more general and formulaic expressions usually describing the submission of the envoys to the Egyptian king. Interestingly, most of these clauses find parallels in the captions of the registers of *Pwnt* and the southern countries of Rekhmire discussed above—and thus, naturally, in their counterpart in the texts of Hatshepsut.

There are, in addition, a couple of clauses in these non-African registers that, while not identical, still exhibit some similarity to other clauses attested in the texts of Hatshepsut discussed here. In particular, in the fourth Register of Rekhmire (i.e., the *Rṯnw* and Levant register, Urk. IV 1101:17) we read:



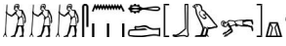
jnw=sn ḫr psd=sn
(while) their *jnw*-contributions are on their back

This is reminiscent of a similar clause in Hatshepsut's inscriptions (H.Ba.5):



mȝʿw=sn ḫr psd=sn
(while) their gifts are on their back

Similarly, the image of the enemies under the sandals of the sovereign, attested in this clause of the fifth Register of Rekhmire (i.e., the registers with the rulers of the northern and southern countries, Urk. IV 1102:17):



wrw=sn ḫḏ[bw] ḫr tb[tʸ]=fʸ
their political leaders having been over[thrown] under his sandals

[36] See, e.g., Den Doncker, "Identifying-Copies in the Private Theban Necropolis" (2017); Laboury, "Tradition and Creativity" (2017) for recent discussions.

[37] See Den Doncker, "Identifying-Copies in the Private Theban Necropolis" (2017).

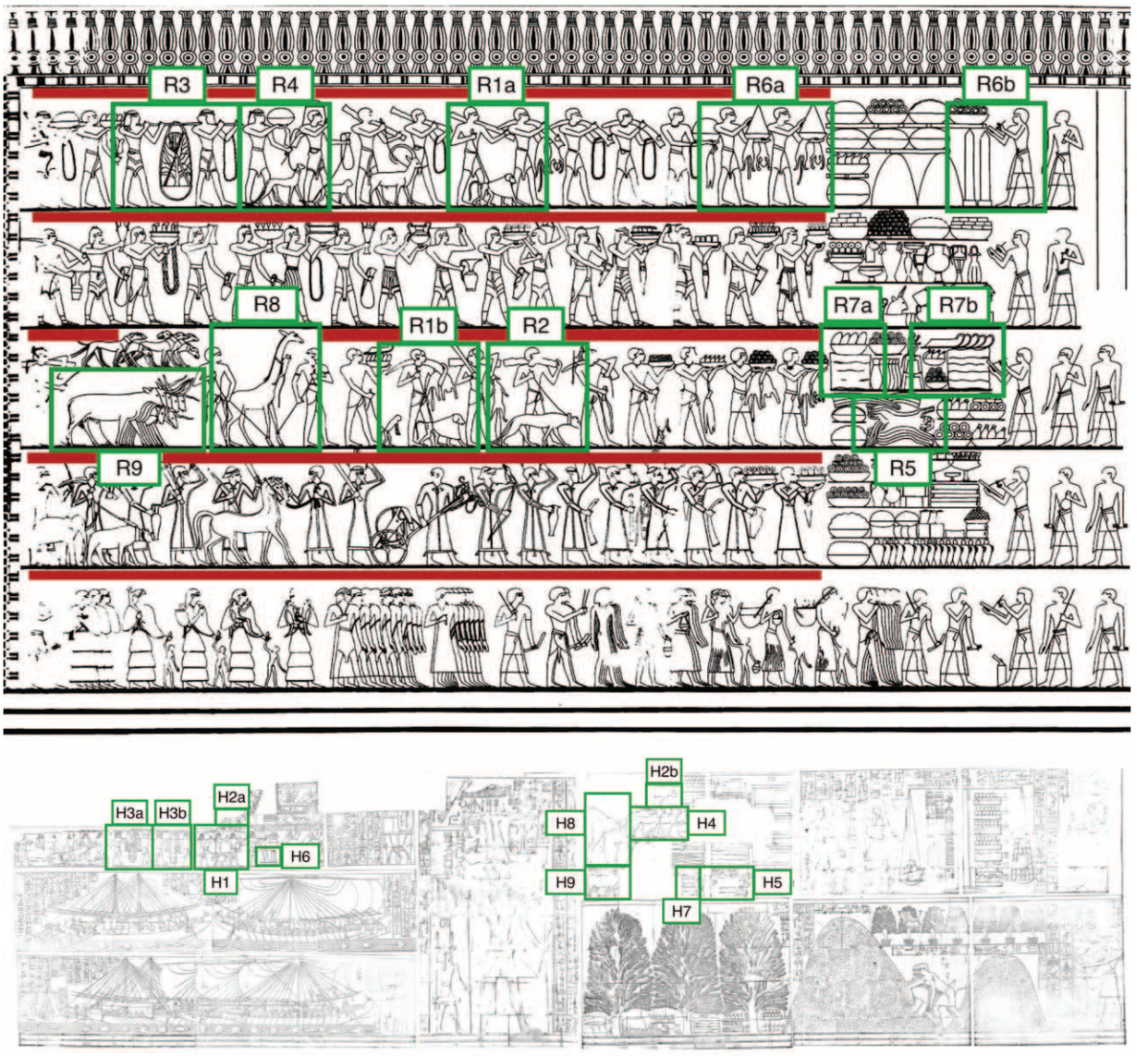


Figure 5—Distribution of the elements listed in Figures 1–4 within the scenes of Rekhmire (top) and Hatshepsut (bottom).[a] The red lines indicate the position of the captions of each register.

[a] Drawings from Naville, *Temple of Deir El Bahari - Part. 3* (1895), pls LXXII–LXXXI; Davies, *Paintings from the Tomb of Rekh-Mi-Rē'* (1935), pl. XXII; Taterka, "Expéditions au Pays de Pount" (2017), 651–61.

might echo this clause of Hatshepsut (H.Ba.10):



rdj tȝw nbw ḥr ṯbtʸ=s
who places all lands under her sandals

Finally, the mention of foreign political leaders bringing their children to the Pharaoh, which can be found in the fifth Register of Rekhmire (Urk. IV 1102:11–12)—





[sṯȝ (?) m]sw wr[w] nw ḫȝswt rs(ʸw)t
m-ᶜb msw [wrw] nw ḫȝswt mḥt(ʸw)t

[Bringing (?) the ch]ildren of the political lead[ers] of the southern foreign countries

as well as the children of the [political leaders] of the northern foreign countries

—has a thematic parallel in the following passage of Hatshepsut (H.Ba.6):



ḫnk=sn n=s m msw=sn
and they present to her their children

It is worth mentioning that at least some of these more formulaic and rhetorical clauses can also be found in other royal inscriptions and private tombs of the Eighteenth Dynasty, particularly during the reign of Thutmose III ().[38] It is thus reasonable to assume that these very formulaic expressions were part of a set of "stock clauses" that scribes tasked with the composition of ideological texts had learned and could use and reuse in various forms and combinations. Yet, overall, it is clear that the non-African registers do not seem to have any word-to-word parallels that are unique to Hatshepsut's inscriptions, as it is instead the case for the African registers. How can we explain this difference?

I see three possible scenarios. A first possibility is to assume that the scribe(s) who composed the captions of the tomb of Rekhmire first created the captions for the registers of *Pwnt* and the southern countries by making a patchwork of clauses from the texts of Hatshepsut. They then composed the other captions, recycling some of the more formulaic clauses and mixing them with more register-specific original clauses that they invented.

A second possibility is to assume that the scribe(s) of Rekhmire did not invent anything, but created these captions combining clauses taken from the texts of Hatshepsut (in the case of the African registers), from the texts of Hatshepsut (for the formulaic clauses), *and* from one or more other lost texts (for the other clauses) for the remaining three non-African registers. In this understanding, the captions of the second and fourth registers of Rekhmire present an intriguing peculiarity. In the second register we find the following clause (Urk. IV 1099:2):



m-mryt wnn ḫr mw n ḫm=f
in the hope of being on the water of His Majesty

While the fourth register has the following clause (Urk. IV 1102:2):

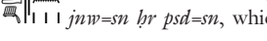


n-mrwt wnn ḫr mw n ḫm=f
in the hope of being on the water of His Majesty

These two clauses are virtually identical, except for the introductory compound preposition which is spelled as *m-mryt* in the first case, and *n-mrwt* in the second. There is no linguistic reason for this difference, and it seems strange to me that the same scribe might have written such a particle in two different ways in the same text. A first explanation could be to assume that different scribes took care of the different captions of Rekhmire, as is well attested in other tombs of the period.[39] Alternatively, this may suggest that, although very similar, these two clauses were copied from different texts that used different forms of the particle. This latter hypothesis would support the scenario under consideration here. A palaeographical analysis of the captions might reveal if they were written by the same scribe/artist or by different scribes/artists, but this is beyond my competence.

Finally, if we assume that both the clauses common to Hatshepsut and Rekhmire may actually come from an earlier, distinct, and lost source, then a third possibility could be that *all* the clauses of *all* registers of Rekhmire come from such a hypothetical source, while it was the scribe(s) of Hatshepsut who made a selection and picked a few formulaic clauses and a few clauses related with *Pwnt* and the southern countries, but left out anything referring to other non-African foreigners. If so, this would mean that this hypothetical prototype was a text that predated the inscriptions of Hatshepsut, included various formulaic clauses describing acts of submission by foreigners, and mentioned at least the same foreign groups listed in Rekhmire's registers, if not more.

I believe the available evidence is insufficient to favor one of these scenarios over the others. However, some considerations are possible. To begin with, I find the first scenario less likely, as it would imply a complete lack of creativity on the side of the scribe of Rekhmire for the labels of the registers of *Pwnt* and the southern countries, oddly (at least in my opinion) combined with a good dose of originality for at least some of the clauses of the other registers. More interesting is the fact

[38] E.g., R.III.10:  *sb=tw rdjt n=sn t3w n ꜥnḫ*; R.I.5:  *[m] wsḫ tp*; Urk. IV 1101:17:  *jnw=sn ḫr psd=sn*, which have parallels in various contemporary texts.

[39] See, e.g., Díaz-Iglesias Llanos, "Hieratic Signs" (2022).

that Passages Ba + Bb of Hatshepsut come from an inscription at Deir el-Bahri that was intentionally erased, probably by agents of Thutmose III.[40] We do not know exactly when this inscription was erased,[41] nor when the scenes in Rekhmire's tombs were painted. However, we do know that Rekhmire served under Thutmose III,[42] and that the decoration of his tomb was modified at the beginning of the reign of Amenhotep II.[43] Thus, the works in his tomb must have started during the later phase of Thutmose III's reign and must have continued during the reign of Amenhotep II, at least to some extent. That said—and if Rekhmire's texts stem from Hatshepsut's texts—then we are left only with the following possibilities: either the scribe(s) of Rekhmire copied these clauses *before* they were erased, or they were taken from a copy that survived the erasure. In both cases, this would imply that Rekhmire employed or kept in his tomb clauses and scenes from Deir el-Bahri after the *damnatio memoriae* of Hatshepsut by Thutmose III. In principle, this is not impossible, and in fact if this were truly what happened, it would open interesting scenarios about the dynamics between the court, the king, and the elites on the one hand, and the workmen, scribes, and artists working in the tombs on the other.

By contrast, the whole picture would be much simpler if we follow the third scenario, namely that the common clauses come from an earlier source. In that case, we could imagine that both Rekhmire's and Hatshepsut's artists took and adapted bits and pieces from an earlier lost source likely composed for one of Hatshepsut's male predecessors. The fact that one of these texts composed for Hatshepsut was then erased by the agents of Thutmose III would have no bearing at all on the history of the captions and scenes in Rekhmire's tomb, because the artists of Rekhmire would have based their work on this earlier, now-lost, and common source, and not on the texts and scenes produced for Hatshepsut. None of these scenarios appears impossible, and I believe we should keep all of them on the table.

Additional Considerations and Conclusions

The clear link between the texts of Hatshepsut and at least some of these captions raises interesting questions that go beyond Rekhmire's scenes themselves. First, these word-by-word parallels provide valuable insight into the processes that operated "behind the scenes" in the decoration of a tomb such as that of Rekhmire. The presence of such intertextuality suggests the circulation, revision, and reuse of textual material. This practice appears to have occurred not only across monumentally distinct settings, such as between royal monuments and private elite tombs, but also across functionally different contexts. In this case, the same clauses are employed both in an "oracular" text concerning a royal expedition to *Pwnt* and in seemingly unrelated scenes depicting Rekhmire's role in the reception of tribute on behalf of the king.[44]

I have sketched here a few scenarios that could explain how this intertextuality materialized in practice, but the considerations put forward above should be understood as preliminary. Perhaps a reassessment of the texts and captions in other contemporary private tombs could reveal additional parallels with the texts of Hatshepsut or others, and might shed additional light on the socio-cultural dynamics underlying this phenomenon.[45]

[40] See, e.g., Taterka, *Expéditions au Pays de Pount* (2017), 214.

[41] But possibly as late as year 42 of Thutmose III: Nims, "Date of the Dishonoring" (1966): 97–100; Dorman, *Monuments of Senenmut* (1988), 46–65; Taterka, *Stosunek Thotmesa III do koregencji* (2016), 179–86; Taterka, *Expéditions au Pays de Pount* (2017), 256.

[42] He may have assumed the title of *i3 ty* shortly after Thutmose III's year 28, possibly around 1451–1448: Duhoux, *Des minoens en Egypte?* (2003), 15; see also Güell i Rous, *Tomb of Vizier Rekhmire* (2018), 38.

[43] *Ibid.*, 46 and *passim*; Den Doncker, *Réactions aux images* (2018), 212–24.

[44] But of course, this sentence of mine has to be taken with caution: what is "apparently unrelated" to us modern scholars (or to me, specifically) may have not been so for the Egyptian scribes and artists that composed these scenes and texts. In this regard, one of the anonymous reviewers asked whether the placement of these representations in Hatshepsut's monuments and Rekhmire's tomb might carry deeper significance, and what may have motivated Rekhmire (or his artists and scribes) to select these specific clauses and iconographic elements. I fully agree that these are important questions, and that there may be layers of meaning beyond what we (or I) currently perceive. At the same time, these issues lie outside the scope of the present paper and, admittedly, my current expertise.

[45] Exploring this possibility is obviously beyond the scope of this paper. It is, however, possible to point out here a few potential candidates, such as the already-mentioned tomb of Puyemre (TT39), the tomb of Djehuty (TT11), where at least a pair of bearers appear to be iconographically similar to those of Rekhmire (see Galán, "Overseer of the Treasury Djehuty" [2020], 160), or in general those of other contemporaries, such as Useramun (TT131), Menkheperresoneb (TT86), or TT143 (unknown owner).

Another compelling question emerging from this study is the historicity (or lack thereof) of these tribute scenes.[46] This is a crucial issue specifically in the case of this scene of Rekhmire's tomb and its *Kftjw* register. Without diving too deep into a debate that has been ongoing for decades, it suffices here to say that Rekhmire's *Kftjw* register has attracted scholarly attention not only because it is a particularly rich and detailed representation of Aegean emissaries, but also because the register appears to be a palimpsest.[47] The Aegean envoys have in fact being depicted over an earlier version of the register which also contained Aegean envoys. While the dresses of the original envoys were formally similar to representations of Aegean people in other tribute scenes in earlier tombs (e.g., in the tomb of Senenmut, under the reign of Hatshepsut), the emissaries of the later version depicted over them are characterized by formally different dresses that have no parallel in previous representations. This palimpsest has attracted much discussion, because scholars have proposed that the change in representation might have been triggered by some historical event. Supporters of this thesis have suggested that the earlier representation might have been highly conventional and based on outdated models based on the memory of some Aegean delegations that arrived in Egypt in earlier times, possibly at the time of Hatshepsut/Senenmut or before. They have also argued that their erasure and substitution with apparently innovative representations could have been triggered by the arrival in Egypt of a new Aegean mission that was characterized by a new distinct style of dressing, which would have pushed Rekhmire (or his artists) to update the depictions in his tomb.[48]

The analysis of captions and scenes presented in this article now confirms that this tribute scene is highly dependent, at least in the texts of its African registers, on some earlier model dating to the reign of Hatshepsut or before. This supports the idea that the first version of the Aegean registers was also based on earlier models and codified representations dating back at least to the time of Hatshepsut, and thus of Senenmut.

At the same time, considering the remarkable lack of inventiveness demonstrated by whoever composed the African captions, one can wonder about how realistic it is that the second version of the *Kftjw* register might truly be a new, innovative representation of Aegean people triggered by a new, contemporary encounter. Obviously, we cannot exclude this possibility, since the captions may have been composed under different circumstances, according to different principles, based on different sources, and/or by different individuals. However, we should at least be cautious in assuming that a tomb owner like Rekhmire (or his team of artists)—who clearly accepted a patchwork of recycled clauses for some of the captions—would suddenly feel compelled to repaint an entire register purely out of a desire for visual or historical accuracy. Rather, it is likely that other factors were at play, and we should therefore be careful in reading tempting but hardly demonstrable historical meanings into such a change. The only sure facts here are that the scenes and captions of the African registers (along with some clauses from other captions) are the result of a patchwork of elements somehow related to the scenes and inscriptions at Deir el-Bahri; and that an earlier set of representations of Aegean emissaries, possibly reminiscent of Senenmut's depictions, was replaced with a distinct second set. Perhaps these two phenomena are somehow related; perhaps their story has more to do with how the decorations of these tombs were conceived and constructed, than with any specific historical event external to them. A reassessment of the texts and captions of similar contemporary tombs might shed some more light on these processes. These in turn might help better interpret the links and diachronic changes we observe in this part of the decoration of Rekhmire's tomb.

[46] See also the discussion in Hallmann, *Tributszenen des Neuen Reiches* (2006).

[47] For a recent discussion, see Den Doncker, *Réactions aux images* (2018), 212–24, with references.

[48] Or this may have been the case already in the TT 86 of Menkheperreseneb, if we follow the idea that the depictions in this tomb are roughly contemporaneous or slightly earlier than those of Rekhmire. For a discussion of this idea, see *ibid*., 220–21.

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